



MOVING PLATES



The Earth's surface is not one unbroken piece. It is made up of many pieces that

fit together like a giant jigsaw puzzle. These pieces, called plates, move as the mantle slowly moves beneath them. The movement of the plates can cause spectacular effects—earthquakes split the crust, volcanoes form, new land is made, and huge mountain ranges are pushed skyward.

On the move

The plates are never still, they are always moving. In one year they can move about 1 inch (2.5 centimeters), about as much as your fingernails grow in the same amount of time.



The red dots show you the places where earthquakes happen.

Continent



All scrunched up

Sometimes, two plates push against each other and then crumple the land to make huge mountain ranges.



Going down

Sometimes, one plate slides under another. It is pushed down into the mantle and melts.



Doing the splits

Sometimes, two plates split apart and lava bubbles up to fill the gap. It hardens and makes new land.



Slip sliding away

Sometimes, two plates slip past each other. This is another kind of movement that causes earthquakes.

